

1 Mating

A male dragonfly holds onto his mate by hooking the end of his abdomen in the groove of her neck. In this position, he passes sperm into her body to fertilize her eggs.

6 Male dragonfly

As flying adults with 4 in (10 cm) wingspans, dragonflies grow no more. They skim close to the surface of the pond, catching prey in midair.

Delicate wings only emerge in the last stage of its life cycle.

**Egg laying**

The female Emperor Dragonfly has a sawlike blade in her abdomen so she can slice into the plant to lay her eggs.

Metamorphosis

Some animals go through such dramatic changes as they grow that their adult forms look very different from their offspring. This kind of development is called metamorphosis.

Such a significant transformation not only causes changes in shape, but in lifestyle, too. Dragonflies and frogs start off as underwater larvae until they are old enough to turn into air-breathing creatures. Similarly, crawling caterpillars must live life in the slow lane before they can become butterflies. In each case, metamorphosis reshapes their bodies to prepare them for the future stages of their life cycle.

2 Eggs

The female Emperor Dragonfly lays hundreds of eggs in water weeds just below the surface of the water. Each egg is narrower at the ends so it slides easily into a plant stem.

3 Nymph

After a few weeks, each egg hatches into a tiny wriggling prolarva, which quickly molts into a nymph that can swim and feed. It walks across the pond floor to hunt.

